a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

Cash & Company

MASTER · CAPSTONE ARC

Capstone Progression

Thirteen capstones. Each builds on the last. None contradict the next.

From kindergarten Cash's Cafe to grade-12 launch-defensible plans - the through-line that makes the program coherent end to end.

CAPSTONE PROGRESSION

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Purpose. Show the explicit Capstone arc K→12: the artifact each grade produces, what it requires of the student, how it builds on the prior year, and what it hands to the next year. This file answers the question "where is this kid going?" for any teacher, parent, or admin reading at any grade level.

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Anchor rule. Capstone artifacts are pulled verbatim from each grade's Curriculum Book and the Master Scope. The progression analysis is original to this document.

The shape of the Capstone arc. From a child finishing one classroom job at age 5, to a young adult defending a portfolio decision at age 18, the Capstone is one continuous artifact getting deeper every year. Each year's Capstone is the entrance ticket to the next.

The Capstone Spine (one line per year)

Grade	Capstone Artifact	What it requires	What carries to next year
K	**Cash's Cafe job + finished thing** — student takes one role in a classroom cafe simulation and shows what they made or did (e.g., the napkin tray they passed out).	Finishing a job; saying whether they did it the way it was supposed to be done.	"I can finish a job and notice if I did it the way I was supposed to."
1	**Classroom Store: Make-or-Do Window** — student picks "make a thing" or "do a thing" and runs that station for one day with a 4-step process card and a sign that names item + price.	Following a 4-step process; making a 3-element sign; finishing one product they would change next time.	The classroom store rhythm; one specific revision they'd make.
2	**Problem Wall + Solve-It Fair** — student finds a real (kid-scale) problem, fills a Problem→Idea card, builds a 5-step setup checklist, and runs the Solve-It station with a customer-helping sign.	Naming a problem; sequencing a setup; writing one piece of feedback from a classmate.	One classmate's specific feedback they wrote down.
3	**Lemonade-Stand Math + 3-Person Trio Pitch** — trio team picks a business idea from a Skills/Hobbies/Needs web, calculates cost/revenue/profit at 3 sales volumes, presents a 1-minute team pitch with logo and name.	Generating 5 ideas; defending one with a reason; cost/revenue/profit math; logo + name.	First profit equation; first business name; first 3-person team experience.

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Grade	Capstone Artifact	What it requires	What carries to next year
4	**$50 Event Budget + 1-Page Plan** — student runs an idea through the 5-question Reality Check, builds a 1-page plan template, fills a $50-cap budget for an event the class will actually run, and writes a before/after diff.	A 1-sentence customer statement; a $50-cap budget that adds correctly; a planning revision they made.	The 1-page plan template; the diff sheet; meeting-running fluency.
5	**Classroom Market Day** — Capstone is a public event. Student sets a price using a target margin, writes a 30-second elevator pitch, runs a stand for one market day, tracks inventory, runs a debrief.	Margin pricing; multi-volume profit prediction; live customer interaction; an honest debrief with 2 specific items.	Pricing fluency; one debrief they wrote about their own work; the experience of having served real customers (peers + family).
6	**One-Month Ledger + SOP + RACI Project** — student runs a hypothetical 12-year-old's small business through an income/expense ledger with a savings-rate goal, writes one SOP, completes a RACI for a 4-task project, runs 2 weekly stand-ups.	Ratios and percents (savings rate); SOP discipline; responsibility clarity; cadence-based reflection.	One real ledger; one real SOP; the stand-up rhythm.
7	**Persona Pack + Day-1 Customer Assumption** — student builds a 1-page customer persona using interview evidence, writes a problem statement in the [Customer]/[problem]/[context]/[cause] format, computes per-customer revenue + contribution margin, files a Day 1 Customer Assumption letter that opens at Day 30 to compare assumptions vs. evidence.	Customer interviewing; persona writing; contribution margin math; Day-1-vs-Day-30 revision.	Persona literacy; first contribution margin number; the experience of seeing your own old assumptions.
8	**Break-Even Calculator + 3-Day A/B Test + PDSA Cycle** — student builds a break-even calculator (units × price = fixed + variable × units), runs a 3-day mini-marketing test on two posters/messages, completes one PDSA cycle on one part of their business, writes a 1-page variance explanation on a 4-week project plan.	Linear equations as business tool; A/B testing; quality-improvement discipline; honest variance.	Break-even literacy; the experience of measuring a change vs. just making it.

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Grade	Capstone Artifact	What it requires	What carries to next year
9	**Business Model Canvas + 5-Interview Discovery + 1-Year P&L + 2-Week MVP Test** — Year 1 of the high-school four-year arc. Student maps a real BMC with evidence in each box, runs 5 customer interviews, builds a 1-year P&L, runs a 2-week MVP test with a "what would have to be true" success metric, writes a kill/iterate/scale recommendation.	Customer discovery; first financial statement; first venture decision based on data.	The BMC artifact (becomes Grade 10's input); the experience of changing your mind on evidence.
10	**Categorization + Funding Comparison + Operating Agreement + Premortem + Brand Guide** — student categorizes their venture (hobby/side hustle/small business/startup), compares 3 funding sources with criteria, completes an operating agreement template for a 2-person partnership, runs a premortem with top 3 risks ranked, writes a 1-page brand guide.	Mature money decisions; governance literacy; pre-failure thinking; brand-as-system.	Entity decision; operating-agreement literacy; the "rank your risks" reflex.
11	**12-Month Cash Flow Forecast + Sales Conversation + 6-Week Venture Sprint + Investor-Style Pitch** — student builds a 12-month cash flow forecast and identifies the cash-tight month with a fix, runs a structured sales conversation in role-play, leads a 3-person team through a 4-week project, completes a 6-week venture sprint with weekly check-ins, delivers a 5-minute investor-style pitch with traction slide and ask, incorporates panel feedback into a revision.	Cash discipline; sales conversation skill; sustained team leadership; pitch revision based on critique.	The 12-month forecast (becomes Grade 12 financial pack input); the "what we learned" slide; the 6-week sprint experience.
12	**Portfolio Defense + Full Financial Pack + Live Launch + 90-Day Plan + Founder's Leadership Statement + Launch-or-Learn Decision** — Capstone Year. Student delivers a portfolio defense (businesses they would and wouldn't start, with reasons), produces a complete startup financial pack (P&L, cash flow, balance-sheet sketch, runway, unit economics), launches a venture or convincing simulation with brand + landing page + 5 real customer interactions, writes and follows a 90-day operating plan with weekly variance, writes a Founder's Leadership Statement, produces a final Launch-or-Learn decision (start, shelve, or transfer).	Three-statement literacy + runway thinking; live customer execution; mature decision-making.	A real portfolio defending the businesses chosen and the businesses declined.

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How the Capstone compounds (the founder's lifecycle in K-12 form)

The Capstone is structured to mirror the actual lifecycle of building a venture, scaled by age and rigor:

- **K-2 — Notice and finish.** The cognitive seed: I can see a problem, take a role, and complete a task.
- **3-5 — Plan and price.** The first time the student writes a plan and connects price to value.
- **6-8 — Operate and measure.** Systems thinking enters; the student can set up something repeatable and read what's happening.
- **9-10 — Model and structure.** The Business Model Canvas is the year's North Star; ownership and money structure follow.
- **11 — Lead and forecast.** The student leads a team and lives with cash flow, the most-felt founder reality.
- **12 — Decide and launch (or decide not to).** The mature founder posture: choose what to build, defend the choice, and execute or honestly walk away.

By Grade 12, a graduate has literally run an idea through every stage of the founder's lifecycle: noticing, ideation, customer evidence, modeling, financing, operating, leading, selling, and deciding. They've done all of it at age-appropriate scale, and the artifacts are in their portfolio.

Capstone defense format by band

The Capstone Defense is the moment the student presents their work to a panel. The format scales by grade band:

K-2 DEFENSE — "SHOW + TELL + ONE THING" (3 MINUTES)

- Show what you made or did.
- Tell who it helped.
- Say one thing you would do differently next time.
- Audience: classmates + teacher + (optional) one family member.

3-5 DEFENSE — "PLAN + PITCH + DEBRIEF" (5–7 MINUTES)

- Show your plan (1-page or trio team plan).
- Deliver your pitch (30-second at Grade 5; shorter at 3 and 4).
- Share your debrief: what worked / what flopped / what you'd change.
- Audience: classmates + teacher + 1–2 invited adults (often a family member or guest).
- Rubric: Pitch Presentation Rubric (5-criterion adapted for K-band).

6-8 DEFENSE — "PERSONA + NUMBERS + TEST + REVISION" (10–12 MINUTES)

- Persona or segment description.

- The numbers (cost/margin/break-even at the appropriate grade).
- The test you ran (A/B, PDSA, Day-1-vs-Day-30 comparison).
- The revision you made because of the test.
- Audience: classmates + teacher + 1–3 invited panelists (other teachers, older students, community members).
- Rubric: Pitch Presentation Rubric (all 6 criteria) + a sub-rubric for the artifact (Customer Research, Budget, or Reflection).

9-12 DEFENSE — "FULL DEFENSE" (15–30 MINUTES)

- 5–10 minutes presenting (the format scales by grade — investor-style pitch at Grade 11, portfolio defense at Grade 12).
- 10–20 minutes Q&A with a panel of 3–5 reviewers (educators, family, community members, business owners — the program calls them "the panel").
- Audience: open to families and other students.
- Rubric: Pitch Presentation Rubric + Business Plan Rubric + Customer Research Rubric all converging on one defense; Grade 12 adds the Reflection Writing Rubric for the Launch-or-Learn memo.

The Defense is never "Shark Tank." The framing is "what did you learn?" not "would I invest?" — the Implementation Guide is explicit on this. Cash never poses as an investor; Cash poses as a curious co-traveler. The panel adopts the same posture.

What the Capstone is NOT

The Capstone is intentionally not several things, because well-meaning programs drift toward these and lose the spine:

- **Not a Shark Tank.** Investor framing rewards confidence over evidence. The Capstone rewards evidence over confidence.
- **Not a craft fair.** A poster with a cartoon mascot and zero math is not a Capstone. The rubrics enforce evidence; the panel enforces honest claims.
- **Not a wealth simulation.** No grade's Capstone has the goal "make the most money." Goals are evidence quality, plan revision, and reasoned decisions.
- **Not a single-track project.** The Capstone has three exit ramps at every grade band: launch (take the venture forward), shelve (decide it's not the right time), transfer (give the artifact to another team or store it as a learning record). All three are honored equally — at every band, with the corresponding rubric criteria.
- **Not a parental project.** Family involvement is welcomed at the showcase but the Capstone is the student's work. Parents are panelists, not co-authors. The Parent Guide is explicit.

What carries forward when a student transfers in mid-arc

When a Cash to Company student transfers to or from a school using the curriculum mid-year:

- **Transferring in:** The receiving teacher reviews the Capstone Journal of the prior year. If it's missing, run the previous grade's Lesson 1 as a 1-day catch-up; the Capstone for the current year proceeds with adjusted depth.
- **Transferring out:** The Capstone Journal travels with the student in a clearly labeled folder. The receiving school can read the student's prior thinking and place them appropriately.

The Capstone Journal is, by design, transferable.

The Capstone artifact list (portable)

A high-school graduate of Cash to Company holds the following physical/digital artifacts:

1. **Grade 5 Market Day debrief** — first market experience, in their words.
2. **Grade 7 Day-1 Customer Assumption letter, opened at Day 30** — first encounter with the gap between thought and evidence.
3. **Grade 9 Business Model Canvas with evidence in each box** — first formal venture model.
4. **Grade 9 5-interview customer-discovery report** — first real customer conversations.
5. **Grade 9 1-year P&L** — first financial statement.
6. **Grade 10 funding-source comparison** — first time they thought about what money costs.
7. **Grade 10 operating agreement template (completed for a partnership scenario)** — first governance artifact.
8. **Grade 10 1-page brand guide** — first systematized brand.
9. **Grade 11 12-month cash flow forecast** — first cash-tight-month identification.
10. **Grade 11 6-week sprint board with retrospective** — first sustained execution record.
11. **Grade 11 5-minute investor-style pitch with revision** — first external critique applied.
12. **Grade 12 startup financial pack (P&L, cash flow, balance sheet sketch, runway, unit economics)** — first integrated financial model.
13. **Grade 12 90-day operating plan with weekly variance** — first founder cadence.
14. **Grade 12 Founder's Leadership Statement** — first articulated leadership identity.
15. **Grade 12 Launch-or-Learn decision memo** — the capstone of capstones.

This portfolio is the student's evidence of capability. The REAL_VENTURE_READINESS_CHECKLIST.md maps each artifact to a standard founder skill.

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Fidelity check (every grade Capstone, scored)

A school running Cash to Company K-12 should run an annual fidelity check. For each grade's Capstone:

- [ ] Was the artifact actually produced (vs. described, vs. promised)?
- [ ] Was the appropriate Rubric Bank rubric used?
- [ ] Did at least one panelist outside the classroom participate (3-12 only; K-2 can be teacher + 1 family)?
- [ ] Did the student deliver a verbal defense (or its band-appropriate equivalent)?
- [ ] Did the student capture 1+ piece of panel feedback in writing?
- [ ] At Grade 12 specifically: did the student make a Launch-or-Learn decision with all three options actually on the table?

If three or more boxes are unchecked at any grade, that grade's Capstone is "in name only" and the school should re-run the unit with the rubric in hand.

End of Capstone Progression. This document and SCAFFOLDING_MAP.md together are the curriculum's nervous system. The Master Scope is the bones; these two are the spine and the spinal cord.

One promise.

A capstone in grade 8 is the prerequisite for the capstone in grade 9. Always.

Cash to Company is built so a curriculum coordinator, a foundation officer, a parent, or a teacher can pick up any one of these strategic references and meet the program at full strength on the first page.

No promise of wealth. No probing of family finances. No partisan content. One question, asked patiently for thirteen years: which people, and how do you know?

For educational and operational use. This document is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment is cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).

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Cash to Company · An entrepreneurship + financial literacy curriculum K-12